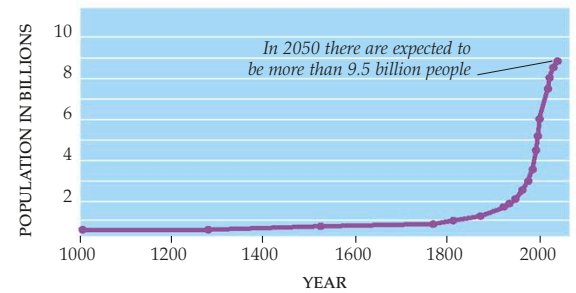


Planet People

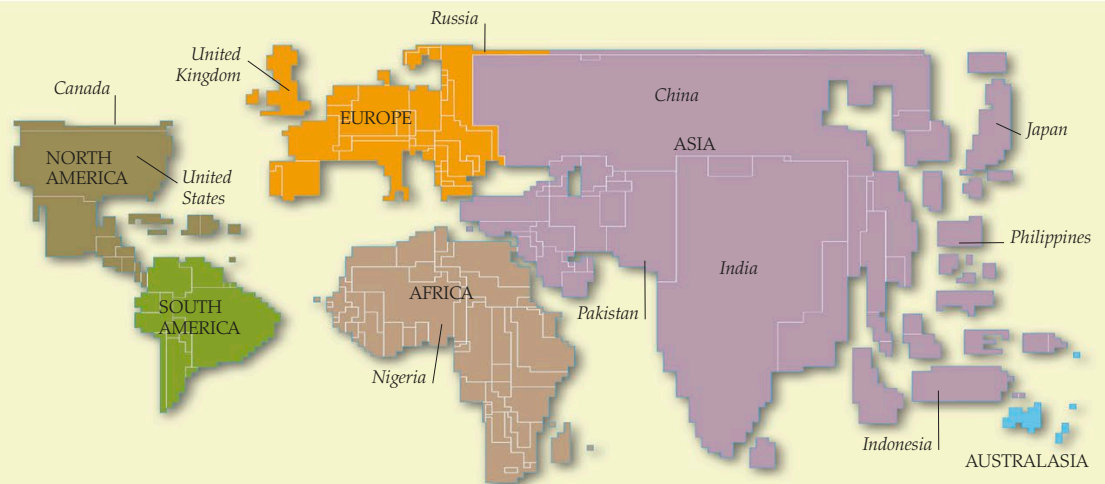
THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE ON THE PLANET has quadrupled since 1900. Much of this growth has taken place in the developing world, which is now home to more than 80 percent of the population. Many of these people are very poor and do not experience the living conditions that most citizens of the developed world take for granted. This is changing, however, especially in nations such as China, India, and Brazil. Here, new technology and international trade are fueling rapid economic growth that is transforming how people live. But as more of the planet's people demand more of its scarce resources, there may be some difficult challenges ahead.



POPULATION INCREASE
For centuries, the number of people on the planet stayed the same, at roughly 300 million. But since the 1750s, better living conditions and health care have allowed more babies to survive, causing a population explosion. Since 1950, the population has soared from 2.5 billion to nearly 7.5 billion today. It will keep growing, but probably not quite so fast.

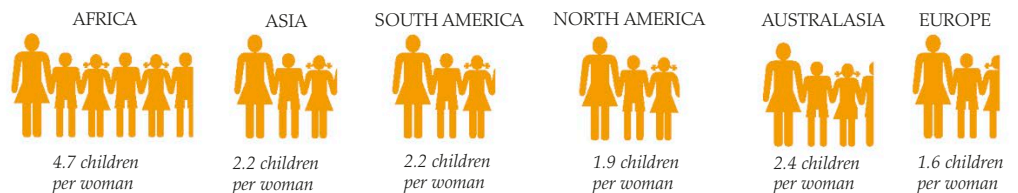
POPULATION DENSITY

On this map the area of each part of the world is adjusted to reflect the number of people who live there. For example, Japan's population of 127 million is far bigger than that of Australia, with 23 million, so it is shown much larger here despite being a smaller country. More people live in Nigeria—186 million—than in all of Russia. But the nations with the biggest populations by far are India and China, each with far more than 1 billion citizens.



FAMILY SIZE

All over the world, some women have more children than others, but the average varies from continent to continent. European women have 1.6 children on average, so two families may have three children between them. This is far fewer than in Africa, where the population is growing faster despite higher death rates among children. Worldwide the average is 2.5—more than enough to replace both parents.



BIRTH AND DEATH RATES

If the birth rate is the same as the death rate, the population stays the same. But in most countries, the birth rate is higher. In Niger, west Africa, there are 44.8 births but only 12.1 deaths per 1,000 people, and the population is growing at 3.2 per cent a year. Brazil's population is also growing, with 14.3 births against 6.6 deaths. By contrast, Lithuania has a shrinking population, with 10 births outweighed by 14.5 deaths.

A country with few young people is said to have an aging population. But these school children in Burundi, east Africa, are part of a youthful population, with fewer old people. Both situations can cause problems.

